

Metro Bank ODI Series England v India



» ANALYSIS

POLISHED, NOT PERFECT

India's ODI ambitions look **sharper than ever** with a settled top-order and a strong fielding unit, but doubts still linger about what its perfect XI looks like.

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For years, India has been trying to perfect the formula to be one of the world's best cricketing sides. From one ODI World Cup cycle to the next, a new deficiency would emerge for the outfit to tackle.

For the longest time, India's fielding was its Achilles heel. A brittle tail would often derail the side's surge against tough opponents. Its pace reserves were seen as lean, its middle order unsettled.

Against this backdrop, India's recent outing in England — which saw victories for the visitor in the five-match T20I series and three-match ODI series — proved to be a much-needed demulcent. India batted with intent, got plenty of validation for its work in grooming a larger bowling pool, and finally clicked as an imposing unit on the field.

That said, this side is just getting started — it would do well to remember.

Track record

The 50-over World Cup gets underway in India, with a spillover in Sri Lanka to accommodate Pakistan, in two months. After a dismal group-stage exit in the T20 showpiece in the UAE, the push to get things right for the One-Day version understandably intensified. On the face of it, India responded well with 14 wins in 20 ODIs.

But the matter of interest is those six losses.